

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Obadiah 1:1

The word vision introduces a prophetic book ([Isa 1:1](#); [Nah 1:1](#)); it also defines what a prophet saw or sensed as a divine word ([Ezek 12:26-27](#); [Dan 8:1](#)). A vision that did not come from the Lord was false ([Jer 14:14](#); [23:16](#)), the ultimate proof being its lack of fulfillment ([Ezek 12:22-24](#)). By contrast, true visions of near or distant events do come to fruition ([Ezek 12:25](#); [Hab 2:3](#)). Prophetic visions came in various forms (dreams, extrasensory experiences; e.g., [Dan 8:2](#)). The absence of visions is a mark of divine abandonment ([Lam 2:9](#); [Ezek 7:26](#); [Mic 3:6](#)).

- Sovereign Lord is one of several names for the God of Israel.
- Obadiah was a common Hebrew name that meant “servant of the Lord.” The prophet Obadiah is unknown apart from this book.
- an ambassador was sent to the nations: In ancient warfare, allies would be contacted about joining a military coalition to punish an enemy or defend against attack. Here the Sovereign Lord calls the nations to redress Edom’s evil pride.
- Let’s assemble: This is a willing coalition, though ironically, they will be punished later for their own evil deeds ([Obad 1:15-16](#)).

Obadiah 1:2-4

I will cut you down: Several messages of judgment rehearse Edom’s specific sins against Israel ([1:10-14](#); [Jer 49:7-22](#); [Ezek 25:12-14](#); [36:5](#)); Edom frequently appears among the nations that opposed Israel and the Lord ([Isa 34](#); [Ezek 35-36](#); [Amos 9:1-15](#)).

- down to size among the nations . . . your own pride: Edom’s rocky topography mimicked Edom’s pride. The height of the mountain fortress that provided their security only emphasizes the height from which Edom would fall. Edomite princes were among the arrogant rulers of the nations ([Ezek 32:29](#); cp. [Gen 36](#); [1 Chr 1:43-54](#)).

Obadiah 1:5

Edom’s destroyers would take everything, unlike thieves and harvesters. Thieves would leave anything that would hinder an immediate,

successful escape; harvesters would always leave gleanings for the poor ([Deut 24:19](#); cp. [Ruth 2](#); [Matt 12:1](#)).

Obadiah 1:5-7

The Babylonians completely destroyed Jerusalem. By sharing in the plunder, Edom deserved equal retribution (see [1:15-18](#)).

Obadiah 1:6

Edom: The Hebrew text uses the name of Esau, Jacob’s brother, indicating Edom’s violation of a fraternal relationship ([1:10-14](#)).

Obadiah 1:7

allies (literally *men of the covenant*): Edom should have been the ally of its brother Israel, but instead, Edom had made a covenant with Babylon.

- promise you peace (literally *men of peace*, paralleling *men of the covenant*): It was poetic justice that Edom’s treachery with Israel was rewarded by Babylon’s treachery against Edom.

Obadiah 1:8

At that time (literally *in that day*): The Hebrew word *yom*, “day,” occurs twelve times in [1:8-15](#), often translated “when” or “at that time.” The time referred to in [1:8](#) is the beginning of the end, when God steps in to reverse the fortunes of his people.

- wise person . . . everyone who has understanding: Edom took pride in its wisdom tradition (cp. [Jer 49:7](#)). For example, the book of Job is set in Edomite territory.

Obadiah 1:10-14

Because of the violence you did . . . in Israel: The basis for Esau’s condemnation is stated in [1:10](#) (cp. [Isa 34](#); [Jer 49:7-22](#); [Joel 3:19](#); [Amos 1:11-12](#)) and amplified in [Obad 1:11-14](#), where Edom’s treachery is described. In legal terms, the evidence

of these verses supports the charge of covenant breaking.

Obadiah 1:11

Outside of this book, nothing specific is known of Edom's role during the various Babylonian invasions of Judah (in 605, 597, and 586 BC). Responsibility toward one's neighbor is a specific requirement of God's law (e.g., [Deut 22:1–4](#); cp. [Matt 25:41–46](#)), especially when there is either a specific "treaty of brotherhood" ([Amos 1:9](#)) or a historical relationship that is regarded as fraternal (see study note on Obad 1:6).

Obadiah 1:12

The tribes of Israel were Edom's relatives (literally *brother*; cp. [Num 20:14](#)). • Edom and other local nations had apparently deceived themselves into thinking that rapprochement with Nebuchadnezzar in 586 BC would bring them respite. Their time of judgment would come.

Obadiah 1:12–14

All societies are held accountable for sins such as those of Edom (see, e.g., the oracles against Israel's neighbors in [Amos 1:3–2:3](#)). Among the sins that the Edomites committed against Judah were sharing with the Babylonians in plundering the land ([Obad 1:13](#)) and either killing or repatriating Judah's fugitives ([1:14](#)).

Obadiah 1:15

The day is near when I, the Lord, will judge (literally *the day of the Lord is near*): Although the day of the Lord was sometimes a temporal event (e.g., the forthcoming destruction of Edom; Joel's locust plague, [Joel 1:15](#)), in its final form that day encompasses God's final retribution on all godless nations. • As you have done: For those who experience judgment, their evil deeds shape their punishment.

Obadiah 1:15–18

The law of retribution (*lex talionis*) is that we harvest what we plant. Edom's treachery, compounded by her pride, would be more than returned when the cup of vengeance came around to her lips. Justice would bring deliverance for Israel and punishment for Edom (see also [Jer 49:7–22](#); [Ezek 32:29](#); [Mal 1:2–5](#)).

Obadiah 1:17

Jerusalem would become a refuge for those who escape. A remnant of Judah remained in Jerusalem (see [Jer 40:11–12](#)). The Lord's mountain of refuge sharply contrasts with Edom's failed cliff fortresses. • their inheritance: The land God gave to Abraham ([Gen 12:1–7](#)) would be returned to his descendants in perpetuity. • the people of Israel: This promise of a return for the people of Judah but not for the Edomites was picked up by the prophet Malachi ([Mal 1:4–5](#)).

Obadiah 1:18

The principle of retribution is expressed in the vivid image of a raging fire burning Edom to extinction. Edomite cities were burned by Babylonian king Nabonidus in 553 BC.

Obadiah 1:19–20

God's people living in the Negev, the foothills of Judah, and Benjamin (three regions of Judah) would possess territories of their neighbors (Edom, the Philistine plains, Gilead). Restored Israel would recover Ephraim and Samaria (territory lost in 722–721 BC to Assyria) and expand its borders to those lands promised in the conquest (the Philistine plains, the land of Gilead, the Phoenician coast). See also [Ezek 47:13–23](#).

Obadiah 1:19–21

History yields to the day when the entire world will belong to the Lord as his kingdom. This message encourages God's people and warns the nations that forget God.

Obadiah 1:20

in the north: Hebrew *in Sepharad*, probably a colony of Jewish exiles in Asia Minor who would return to the Negev. The scene corresponds with some actual events but looks beyond any single movement of refugees to the end times.

Obadiah 1:21

to Mount Zion: God's people would ascend his holy mountain to rule over (or *to judge*) the mountains of their ancient foe Edom as a precursor to the coming universal Kingdom.